

EG Ukraine: Zelensky's concession restores calm but lasting political costs persist

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Ukraine

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Zelensky's concession restores calm but lasting political costs persist

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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- * President Volodymyr Zelensky's decision to dismiss General Oleksandr Syrsky on 21 July and appoint General Mykhailo Drapaty will likely be received positively by both the public and the army.
 - * The protests will likely fade without radicalizing, but Zelensky has emerged weakened.
 - * The war effort is unlikely to suffer, but Zelensky will now have to weigh the public reaction before making major personnel and policy decisions for the duration of the war.
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In the immediate aftermath, the dismissal of Syrsky and the appointment of Drapaty satisfy both the public and the military ranks. Zelensky dismissed Syrsky on 21 July, six days after the removal of the popular defense minister, Mykhailo Fedorov, triggered the largest wartime protests to date (see: [Ukraine: Fedorov's ouster will cost Zelensky more than it solves](#)). Drapaty is genuinely popular within the army. As Ground Forces commander, he pushed back against the problems soldiers associate with the General Staff: fear-driven management, performative discipline, and the gap between headquarters and frontline units. He also endorsed Fedorov's reform agenda the day after the minister's dismissal, earning credibility with protesters and ranks alike. Western allies, who were critical of Fedorov's dismissal, will also welcome Drapaty's appointment.

The mostly young protest movement had turned Syrsky into a symbol of the post-Soviet military order: centralized, hierarchical, attritional, and indifferent to soldiers' lives. That framing is too narrow. While the protesters' concerns are legitimate, the problems are systemic. Syrsky embodied them but did not create them alone. One appointment cannot displace the old command culture, but the choice of Drapaty, a commander who fought it from within, signals that modernization is possible. The real test is what happens to Chief of the General Staff Andrii Hnatov and the promised restructuring of the General Staff.

Fedorov's return to the defense ministry is not certain. First, the position is no longer vacant. Acting Defense Minister Yevhenii Khmara helped select Drapaty and will probably win confirmation. More importantly, Fedorov understands that he could achieve little in the role without the level of presidential trust he once enjoyed. Unless Zelensky offers Fedorov his old job back and assures him that he can carry it out fully, Fedorov will remain on the sidelines. Zelensky will be cautious about granting him that much authority if he can avoid it. Reconciliation and a later return to government in a different capacity remain plausible, but only if Fedorov judges that he has sufficient autonomy to execute his vision.

The protests will likely fade even as trust in Zelensky declines. With one demand met and the other largely moot, demonstrators lack a clear rallying point, and the movement will probably lose momentum. A shift toward more extreme demands, such as Zelensky's removal, remains very unlikely: the wartime consensus holds, and most Ukrainians still place stability above politics. Removing a commander-in-chief is the furthest the public has gone in testing that consensus, but a wide gap remains between that step and calls for the president to resign.

The protests also may have done Zelensky a partial favor. The original accusations posed the greatest political risk: that Fedorov was becoming too popular and threatened entrenched procurement interests. The protests helped recast the conflict as a management dispute, which Zelensky eventually resolved by removing both parties.

That may limit the damage but will not erase it: Zelensky's trust rating will probably fall, as it did after the dismissal of General Valerii Zaluzhnyi in 2024, adding to the damage from the Mindichgate scandal and broader governance grievances.

In the long run, the crisis confirms that Zelensky has lost much of the decision-making freedom he enjoyed in the early years of the war. He will now have to weigh the public reaction before making major personnel and policy decisions for the rest of the war.

Zelensky is also more vulnerable to scandals, parliamentary defections, and future electoral challengers. Another misstep, or more Mindichgate revelations, would carry a higher political cost at a time of weaker public standing. Governance will become harder if deputies begin to view association with the president as politically harmful. Even Prime Minister Serhiy Kiretsky's capable new cabinet may not offset that dynamic.

Zelensky has also raised the profile of potential future rivals. Fedorov now joins Zaluzhnyi as a credible postwar challenger. Drapaty could become a third, depending on how his tenure develops. The timing of the next election will shape how much of the damage endures. The later the vote, the more time Zelensky will have for the episode to fade.

The war effort is, however, unlikely to suffer and may even benefit at the margins. Drapaty's appointment will boost morale and could give new recruits more confidence, helping mobilization. More consequentially, it will accelerate the doctrinal shift Fedorov championed and accused Syrsky of sabotaging: away from matching Russia manpower-for-manpower and toward asymmetric warfare to reduce Ukrainian casualties while raising Russian losses. Reform momentum on procurement, recruitment, and the corps system may also recover, partly offsetting the setback we flagged when Fedorov was dismissed. Further personnel changes in the General Staff would be important for the culture shift and the reform effort.

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